

The Cities Paul Wrote To

Paul's letters have street addresses. Corinth, Ephesus, Philippi, Rome. Knowing the city explains why each letter worries about what it worries about.

THE PREMISE

Letters Have Addresses

We tend to read Paul's letters as chapters in a theology book, interchangeable except for the titles. They are not chapters. They are mail. Each one was carried down real roads to a real city with its own economy, its own gods, its own anxieties, and each letter bends around the shape of the place it was sent to.

This is not a threat to the authority of the letters. It is how their authority works. God did not speak into a vacuum. He spoke to Corinth, which had a status problem, and to Philippi, which had a citizenship problem, and the speech lands harder, not softer, once you know what the first readers were facing on an ordinary Tuesday.

Four cities will do the work. Watch how the local situation surfaces in the text.

CORINTH

Corinth: New Money and Old Hunger

Rome destroyed Greek Corinth in 146 BC and left it desolate. A century later Julius Caesar refounded it as a Roman colony, settling it largely with freedmen, former slaves starting over. By Paul's day it was rich, commercial, and young, a city with no old aristocracy where status had to be earned and displayed. Bruce Winter and others have shown how fierce the competition was. Civic honors, patron and client networks, lawsuits as a respectable way to humiliate rivals, dinner parties where guests were seated and fed by rank.

Now read 1 Corinthians. Factions boasting in celebrity teachers. Believers dragging each other before pagan courts. A Lord's supper where the wealthy eat well while the poor go hungry, the standard banquet of the city replayed at the table of Christ. Boasting, everywhere boasting.

Paul's answer is aimed at exactly this city. Not many of you were wise by worldly standards, not many

powerful, not many of noble birth. God chose what is low and despised. To a town of social climbers he preaches a crucified Lord and a body where the weaker members receive the greater honor. The letter is not general advice. It is surgery.

EPHESUS

Ephesus: The Goddess Was the Economy

Ephesus was the great city of the province of Asia, and its anchor institution was the temple of Artemis, one of the seven wonders of the ancient world, roughly four times the footprint of the Parthenon. The temple was not only a shrine. It functioned as a bank, a tourist draw, and an employer. Pilgrims came, festivals filled the calendar, and craftsmen sold silver shrines of the goddess.

That is why the riot in Acts 19 reads the way it does. Demetrius the silversmith does not open with theology. He opens with revenue. This Paul has persuaded many people that gods made with hands are not gods, and our trade is in danger. Only then does he add that the temple of the great goddess may be discounted. Two hours of shouting follow. Great is Artemis of the Ephesians.

The gospel threatened the business model of an entire city, and the city noticed. Ephesians, written into this world, says almost nothing about Artemis by name and everything about the powers, every rule and authority and dominion, under the feet of Christ. Converts there burned their own magic books, at enormous cost, before anyone made them. The text records the price. Fifty thousand pieces of silver.

PHILIPPI

Philippi: A Colony of Veterans

In 42 BC, the plain outside Philippi hosted one of the deciding battles of the Roman civil wars. Afterward, and again after Actium, Rome settled discharged soldiers there and made the city a Roman colony with the highest legal privileges, governed by Roman law, proud of Latin, proud of the emperor, proud above all of citizenship. A colony was Rome in miniature, far from Rome. Acts catches the accent exactly. The charge against Paul and Silas there is that they advocate customs not lawful for us as Romans to accept.

Now hear Philippians 3:20 the way a veteran's grandson heard it. Our citizenship, our politeuma, is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ. Every loaded word in that sentence had a local meaning. Citizenship was the city's treasure. Savior and lord were the emperor's titles. Paul takes the vocabulary Philippi was proudest of and reassigns it.

The point was not code-breaking rebellion. It was reorientation. Live as citizens worthy of the gospel, he tells them, a colony of heaven holding its outpost with joy, even when the local empire puts its preachers in stocks. He had been in their jail. They knew he was not speaking in theory.

ROME

Rome: After the Expulsion

Around AD 49 the emperor Claudius expelled Jews from Rome. The historian Suetonius says the trouble involved constant disturbances at the instigation of one Chrestus, which most scholars take as a garbled reference to disputes over Christ inside the synagogues. Acts 18 mentions the expulsion in passing. It is why Priscilla and Aquila, Jewish believers, were in Corinth for Paul to meet.

Then Claudius died, the edict lapsed, and Jewish believers returned to a Roman church that had spent years becoming largely Gentile in leadership and habit. Two communities, one table, and a quarrel over food, calendar, and who counts as strong.

Read Romans with that history in view and the letter's long argument lands differently. Jew first and also Greek, repeated like a drumbeat. God's unrevoked faithfulness to Israel in chapters nine through eleven. The command in chapter fourteen to stop despising and stop judging, and in chapter fifteen to welcome one another as Christ welcomed you. The deepest theology in the New Testament was written, in part, to get two estranged groups of Christians to eat dinner together. That is not a small application of the doctrine. That is what the doctrine is for. Context does not shrink these letters. It tells us they were written to people in rooms like ours, and then it hands us our own mail.

KEY TEXTS

1 Corinthians 1:26-29

Philippians 3:20

Acts 18:1-3

SOURCES

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